

CHARLES HARLESS

Software Engineering Manager

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Software Engineering Manager with 15+ years of experience delivering mission-critical platforms for Disney, Amazon, and NBCUniversal. Launched Disney Movies Anywhere to 20M+ users, led global supply chain engineering at Amazon Prime Video, and guided distributed teams building enterprise media systems at scale. Translated ambiguous business priorities into clear engineering roadmaps, reduced operational drag through rigorous prioritization, and grew engineers into senior contributors.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere with 3.5M mobile downloads and 20M+ users within the first month
- Reduced engineering backlog by 75% in 30 days at Brightcove through a prioritization framework
- Improved deployment frequency by 20% via CI/CD pipeline modernization and automated testing
- Decreased system latency by 25% through distributed systems architecture improvements
- Drove 40% improvement in team engagement through structured mentorship and performance coaching
- Reduced AWS cloud operating costs by 15% through infrastructure sizing and architectural guidance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineering Manager (Independent Consulting)

Jan 2024 - Present

Thinking Bear Productions — Los Angeles, CA (remote)

Advise organizations on platform architecture, delivery, and technical operations across media and cloud.

- Advised engineering organizations across 5 clients on distributed systems and cloud strategy
- Raised organization velocity by 20% through backlog management and Agile engineering practices
- Identified AWS infrastructure optimizations reducing cloud operating costs by 15%
- Authored LinkedIn articles on technical architecture and engineering leadership

Computer Science Instructor

Aug 2015 - Dec 2019 | Aug 2023 - Present

UCLA Extension — Los Angeles, CA (hybrid)

Teach Java, data structures, and web applications to working professionals and career-transitioning engineers.

- Taught Java Programming, Data Structures, and Web Applications across 20 sections and 200+ students; sustained a 4.7 / 5.0 instructor rating throughout both tenures

Software Engineering Manager

Jan 2023 - Jun 2023

Brightcove — Boston, MA (remote)

Led 2 engineering teams responsible for media management and content platform services used by worldwide.

- Led 2 teams of 15 engineers building media management applications for 2,500+ global customers
- Reduced application latency by 25% and enhanced system stability through architecture refactoring
- Resolved 75% of engineering backlog within 30 days by introducing an Agile prioritization framework
- Boosted team engagement scores by 40% through weekly 1:1s, feedback, and growth plans
- Role eliminated during company-wide reduction in force

Software Development Manager

Jan 2021 - Jun 2022

Amazon Prime Video — Culver City, CA (hybrid)

Led engineering for systems supporting Prime Video's global media supply chain.

- Led engineering development of services managing 800+ streaming content licensing contracts
- Increased engineering team velocity by 15% through a data-driven prioritization framework
- Defined a 3-year engineering roadmap aligning technical investment with business strategy
- Hired 2 engineers and promoted 2 engineers, expanding team capability and providing career pathways
- Coordinated a security remediation rollout across 2,000+ applications, completing in under 1 week
- Role concluded following organizational restructuring

Staff Software Engineer / Engineering Lead

Apr 2016 - Dec 2020

NBCUniversal — Universal City, CA (on-site)

Led engineering for internal mobile and platform systems supporting employee communications and workflows.

- Led a team of 5 engineers developing internal mobile applications supporting 23,000+ employees globally
- Redesigned push notification system, increasing engagement by 10% while reducing opt-outs by 20%
- Architected and implemented 5 new features for mobile applications, enhancing user functionality

Principal Software Engineer

May 2015 - Mar 2016

Sage Software — Irvine, CA (hybrid)

Led front-end development for Innovation Labs exploring new technology for financial sector.

- Led development of a cross-platform mobile framework adopted across 5 enterprise products
- Authored engineering standards improving code quality and long-term maintainability by 15%

Staff Software Engineer

Nov 2011 - Apr 2015

Walt Disney Studios — Burbank, CA (on-site)

Built and launched distributed media systems supporting Disney's digital distribution platforms.

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere streaming platform achieving 20M+ registered users and 3.5M mobile downloads within the first month
- Deployed high-availability streaming media infrastructure maintaining 99.9% uptime for 4TB of content using adaptive bitrate (HLS/DASH) and DRM technologies
- Prototyped a Beacon-based indoor navigation system improving visitor wayfinding in buildings by 25%
- Designed a blockchain-based digital entitlement delivery reducing projected delivery costs by 20%

Senior Software Engineer

Dec 2005 - Oct 2011

Walt Disney Parks & Resorts — Glendale, CA (on-site)

Engineered reusable solutions for Theme Park Operations and Architecture teams.

- Led engineering for 12 award-winning consumer-facing websites
- Established LAMP architecture standards improving development speed and reliability by 30%

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Master of Science in Computer Science** — University of California, Los Angeles
- **Bachelor of Science in Computer Science** — University of Alabama
- **Certified ScrumMaster** & Certified Scrum Product Owner — Scrum Alliance
- Generative AI Fundamentals Certificate — Databricks
- AWS Cloud Practitioner Essentials — Amazon Web Services

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Cloud Platforms:** AWS (Lambda, ECS, S3, API Gateway), Docker, CloudFormation
- **Streaming Media:** HLS, DASH, DRM (Widevine & FairPlay), CDN architecture
- **Software Development:** Java, Spring, Node.js, JavaScript, TypeScript, React
- **Architecture:** Microservices, distributed systems, REST APIs, CI/CD, DevOps
- **Developer Tools:** GitHub, Jenkins, SQL, NoSQL